

The Quiet Hour

Chapter One

The lighthouse had been dark for eleven years before Mira decided it was her problem. She had walked past it every morning of that time, and every morning it had looked back at her with the same patient indifference, and somewhere in the eleventh winter the arrangement stopped feeling neutral.

Her father would have called this a symptom. He had a whole vocabulary for the things people did instead of sleeping, instead of eating, instead of speaking to one another about the thing that had actually happened. Mira had inherited the vocabulary and almost none of the discipline that was supposed to come with it.

The door was not locked. That was the first surprise, and it reorganised the others behind it. She had prepared for a lock, had a crowbar in the boot of the car and a story ready for anyone who asked, and instead the handle turned with the small mechanical courtesy of a thing that has been waiting.

TWO

Inside, the air was colder than the air outside, which she had not expected and could not immediately explain. Salt had got into everything. The stairs went up in a spiral so tight it felt less like climbing than like being screwed slowly into the sky, and by the fourth turn she had lost any sense of which way the sea lay.

You can tell how long a building has been empty by what the birds have decided about it.

Someone had written that on the wall of the second landing, in pencil, in handwriting she recognised before she let herself recognise it. She stood with her palm flat against the plaster for a long moment. Then she kept going, because the alternative was to stop, and stopping was the one thing she had come here specifically not to do.

At the top, the lamp room opened out into more light than the whole rest of the country seemed to hold. The great lens sat in its cradle, intact, patient, filmed over with eleven years of nothing. It was not broken. Nobody had ever said it was broken. They had only said it was finished, which she now understood to be a different claim entirely.

THREE

The mechanism took her four days. It was not difficult work so much as work that refused to be hurried: every bearing wanted cleaning, every brass fitting wanted a particular kind of attention, and the whole assembly had opinions about the order in which it would consent to be reassembled.

On the evening of the fourth day she cranked the weight to the top of its travel, released the escapement, and stood back. The lens began to turn. It turned with a sound she had been hearing in her sleep since she was six years old, a low grinding sigh, and then the beam swung out across the water and found the horizon exactly where her father had always said it would be.

She did not cry. She had expected to and had prepared some private embarrassment about it in advance, and in the event she simply sat down on the iron floor and watched the light go round, and round, and round, and thought about how few things in this world will still work if you only ask them properly.